

Chapter 47-1: Obsession

That smile vanished in an instant, but it lingered in Ning Fuyi's mind for a long time, like snow beginning to melt under brilliant sunlight - beautifully indescribable.

Ning Fuyi's tail twitched, and her little hamster heart beat as loudly as a human's.

A strange thought suddenly crossed her mind: Chu Qingqiu's cold and distant demeanor already attracted so many admirers - if others saw this smiling appearance, wouldn't it create even more romantic troubles?

"Wipe yourself." Chu Qingqiu said, walking back to the meditation cushion and sitting cross-legged again with her eyes closed, her mood still somewhat dazed.

She wasn't unfamiliar with cleaning Ning Fuyi's body, but that was when Ning Fuyi was still a crying infant whom Ning Changfeng had carelessly dumped at Purple Cloud Peak, covered in spit-up milk.

It was just that back then, she only found that little bundle noisy and annoying.

Ning Fuyi snapped out of her daze, grabbing the fragrant handkerchief to wipe her fur. Finally, like a real golden hamster, she shook off the remaining water droplets before hopping down from the incense altar to bounce over to Chu Qingqiu's side.

Looking up, she saw that Chu Qingqiu kept her eyes closed as if in meditation. Only then did Ning Fuyi lift Chu Qingqiu's wide sleeve to discover that the wound deep enough to see bone had already scabbed over, and the bloodstains had been wiped clean.

But wounds caused by Red Spider Lilies were carved into the soul, not the flesh¹. So they were irreversible - whether through reincarnation or soul possession, they could never be removed.

She lowered the sleeve, her doubts growing stronger. Had Chu Qingqiu truly cultivated the Heartless Way or not?

Though there were no ghosts in the temple, it was after all dedicated to the Yama Kings, so there were plenty of cold winds. Especially with Ning Fuyi's fur still half-wet, when the wind blew, her entire body shivered.

She used her claws to groom her fur, her small eyes glancing at Chu Qingqiu.

When she was human, she didn't dare get close, but now that she'd been transformed into an animal, overstepping a bit should be fine. After thinking this through, she leaped onto Chu Qingqiu's shoulder and pulled a strand of hair from behind her to wrap around herself.

Chu Qingqiu's eyelids fluttered, but she didn't stop her.

Chu Qingqiu's hair carried a clear fragrance, like fresh flower tea. The strands were black and smooth. Ning Fuyi took a deep breath and lay down with her belly up.

However, though Chu Qingqiu's shoulder was beautiful, it was rather too thin and bony. After lying there for a while, she felt quite uncomfortable. Ning Fuyi had to spread out the hair and slide down along the front of her robes, settling in the fabric draped over her crossed knees and pulling the sleeves over herself to block the wind. Only then did she feel much warmer.

As she lay there, she began to snore softly.

Chu Qingqiu, who had remained silent all this time, now opened her eyes and wordlessly reached out to smooth her hair that Ning Fuyi had tangled into a mess and straighten her wrinkled front robes, her eyelashes lowered.

The small, plump golden hamster was curled into a ball, sleeping defenseless in her embrace.

"It's better now - she sleeps as soon as she wants to." She murmured quietly to herself, extending a finger to touch the fluffy hamster tail. The tail trembled and swayed away.

Chu Qingqiu stared at Ning Fuyi for a long time, her hair covering her brows and eyes, also concealing the expression in her eyes.

After an unknown amount of time, she hooked her fingertip under her sleeve and carefully, very carefully covered Ning Fuyi with it before closing her eyes again.

Ning Fuyi was awakened by a gust of cold wind. The wind swept across the surface of her skin like icy hooks, making every hair on her body stand on end.

She instantly opened her eyes, and at the same time Chu Qingqiu opened hers too. When the two looked at each other, Ning Fuyi realized something was wrong - her viewing angle of Chu Qingqiu had completely changed. She was now nestled in her embrace with only her legs dangling outside.

The two were really quite close. Ning Fuyi's cheeks flushed with heat, and she shot up like a spring, not yet adjusted to human legs and nearly stumbling. Fortunately, she caught herself against the incense altar and managed to stand steady.

Chu Qingqiu was obviously not composed either. She pressed her lips tightly together and quickly stood up, the white bone sliding from her waist into her palm as she faced the temple entrance.

Footnotes:

¹ **carved into the soul, not the flesh (刻在灵魂上而非血肉):** This refers to the metaphysical nature of the Red Spider Lily wounds - they affect one's spiritual essence rather than just the physical body, making them permanent across lifetimes